

Songs *in the* Key *of* THREE

A trio senior recital by
Ilana Diddams, piano
Tomoko Hida, violin
Maia Cheng Penuel, cello

with
Lemuel Gurtowsky, piano
Caro Faust, violin

Sunday, April 12th, 2026
7:00 PM
Sweeney Concert Hall, Sage Hall

program

Piano Trio No. 2 in E Minor, Op. 67 (1943-44)
IV. *Allegretto – Adagio*

Dmitri Shostakovich
(1906-1975)

Trois Pièces pour Violoncelle et Piano (1914)
Modéré in E-flat Minor

Nadia Boulanger
(1887-1979)

5 Pieces for 2 Violins and Piano (1970)
Prelude
Gavotte
Elegy
Waltz
Polka

Dmitri Shostakovich
Arr. Lev Atovmyan
(1905-1981)

Caro Faust, violin
Lemuel Gurtowsky, piano

Cello Suite No. 4 in E-Flat Major, BWV 1010 (1717-23)
III. *Courante*

Johann Sebastian Bach
(1685-1750)

Violin Sonata No. 1 in G Minor, BWV 1001 (1720)
I. *Adagio*

Johann Sebastian Bach

Prelude No. 4, from 9 Preludes, Op. 103 (1910)

Gabriel Fauré
(1845-1924)

Novelette in B-flat Minor from *Trois Novelettes*, FP 47/173 (1928)

Francis Poulenc
(1899-1963)

Cello Sonata in C Major, Op. 119 (1949)
I. *Andante grave - Moderato animato*

Sergei Prokofiev
(1891-1953)

Lemuel Gurtowsky, piano

The Four Seasons of Buenos Aires (1965-69)
III. *Primavera Porteña*

Astor Piazzolla
(1921-1992)
Arr. José Bragato
(1915-2017)

Please silence all cell phones and electronic devices.

notes

Nov 9, 2024 at 12:14

Maia

What are the chances that you would want to be in a chamber group next semester

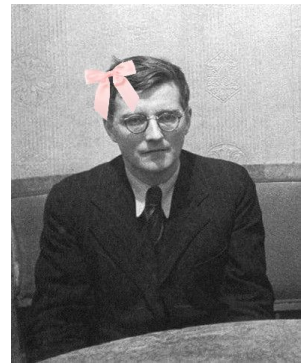
And would Ilana be open to it too...

There's just this piano trio that I played over the summer that was just so amazing it's the Shostakovich piano trio in E minor Op 67

Our program starts and ends with two piano trios – works composed or arranged for piano, violin, and cello – and the origin of this recital goes all the way back to when Tomoko texted Maia in 2024 about a “***** amazing” piano trio by Shostakovich. Many months transpired and in Fall 2025 we finally realized Tomoko’s vision with the help of Jiayan Sun and Interlibrary Loan. Like sonatas, piano trios are extended chamber music compositions (usually three to four movements long), meaning that the themes and melodies are (meant to be) balanced across each instrument, instead of held by only one player.



Dmitri Shostakovich composed his Trio No. 2 in E Minor near the climax of World War II and Nazi Germany’s power, deeply troubled by both personal and large-scale loss. Dedicated to his friend, the musicologist, polymath, and essayist Ivan Sollertinsky, the trio travels through despair and frenzy in four movements. Shostakovich was deeply impacted by Sollertinsky’s death; a February 1944 letter to a friend reads, “We shall not see him again. I have no words with which to express the pain that racks my entire being.”¹ Another reads, “I still can’t recover from my grief...Ivan Sollertinsky was a real champion of our art...It is so offensively sad that there has not been a single response to this tragic loss in our newspapers.”² The trio debuted later that year in November 1944.



In the fourth movement which we are playing today, Shostakovich employs a Jewish dance theme, later borrowed again for his String Quartet No. 8 (1960). The theme is first played by the piano at the beginning of the movement, then cycles between violin, two strings, and piano.



Piano part from Trio No. 2, mvt. IV, showing the movement’s main theme (mm. 31-42)

¹ *Story of a Friendship: The Letters of Dmitry Shostakovich to Isaak Glikman, 1941-1975*, Faber (2001), 24.

² “1944,” Dmitri Shostakovich Archive, *DSCH Publishers*, <https://web.archive.org/web/20251117103118/https://www.shostakovich.ru/en/life/1944/>, Accessed 4 April 2026.

Shostakovich wrote of Jewish folk music in his posthumously published (and controversial) memoir: “it can appear to be happy while it is tragic. It's almost always laughter through tears....They express despair in dance music.”³ As you are listening, let the movement’s “dance of despair” surround you with its grieving momentum.

Nadia Boulanger was born to a musical family in Paris and spent seven decades as a teacher of hundreds of 20th-century composers, including Astor Piazzolla whose work is also featured on this program. *Trois Pièces* was originally composed for organ in 1911, and later arranged for cello and piano. The piece begins in a slow *modéré*, speeding up to a fierce passion in the middle. Then, just as quickly as the piece’s excitement arrives, it ebbs back into a soft, sweet lament. The cello plays with a mute (or *sourdine*), which dampens sound and makes the tone more breathy. Boulanger ceased composing in 1918 at the death of her sister, the composer Lili Boulanger, and this piece is one in a small repertoire of works that Boulanger wrote from the start of her active years in 1905 to the end of her composing career.



Astor Piazzolla (left) and Nadia Boulanger (right) at Boulanger’s home in February, 1955

Shostakovich’s 5 Pieces for 2 Violins and Piano is an arrangement of film and ballet suites for home and school performance by Lev Atovmyan, the composer’s friend and longtime collaborator. Prelude (I) and Elegy (III) come from Atovmyan’s orchestral arrangement of Shostakovich’s score for *The Gadfly*, a 1955 Soviet film about a young theological student-turned-revolutionary in Italy during the Risorgimento (Unification).⁴ Gavotte (II) and Polka (V) were selected from the ballet *The Golden Age* (1930), a satire on the cultural changes of 1920s Europe in which a wrongly imprisoned football team is freed by local workers who overthrow their capitalist overlords.⁵ The origin of Waltz (IV) is less precise, but it is most widely known to be an arrangement of Waltz II from the Suite for Variety Orchestra No. 1 (premiered 1988).⁶

Johann Sebastian Bach composed both the Cello Suites and Sonatas and Partitas for Solo Violin in the same period from 1717-1723 during his time as *Kapellmeister* (music master) for the court at Köthen, Central Germany. Both pieces are unaccompanied; as you listen, try to pick out the different voices (bass, rhythm, harmony, melody) contained within the solo instrumentation.

The Cello Suite No. 4 in E-Flat Major has 3 flats (*Bb*, *Eb*, *Ab*), meaning that the resonant open A-string is seldom used for this suite. For this reason, the suite is known for a dark, warm sound. The third movement is a courante—literally, “running”—a lively couples’ court dance in $\frac{3}{4}$ time.

Bach based the form of his Violin Sonata No. 1 in G Minor on the Baroque convention in which a basic melody was written out and then improvised over by players. For this sonata, Bach wrote down his improvisational intuition between chord progressions, allowing us to replicate a range of theatrics in meticulous detail. The key of G minor itself lends to this character as well—described in Baroque-period

³ Dmitri Shostakovich, *Testimony*, Harper & Row (1979), 156.

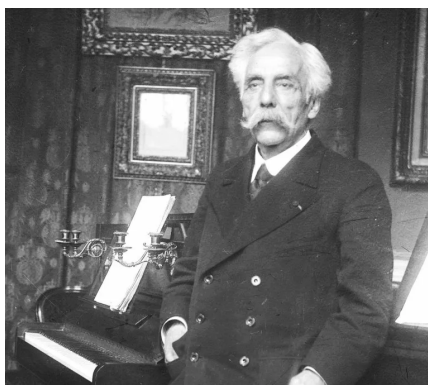
⁴ “The Gadfly Suite,” *Wikipedia*, 5 Jul. 2025. Web.

⁵ “The Golden Age (Shostakovich),” *Wikipedia*, 9 Jan. 2026. Web.

⁶ “Suite for Jazz Orchestra No. 2,” *Wikipedia*, 15 Dec. 2025. Web.

theory by Mattheson as “almost the most beautiful key...rather serious combined with spirited loveliness, uncommon grace and complaisance... suitable for tender as well as refreshing things.”⁷

Gabriel Fauré was a French Romantic composer, “party animal,” and “irresistible to women.”⁸ As the director of the Paris Conservatoire, he was a lifelong teacher to younger composers (including Nadia Boulanger), and a key figure in the movement to establish a French style of composition. Prelude No. 4 employs a hemiola throughout the piece, where three beats are fit into the normal two-beat rhythm. The piece alternates between emphasizing two and three beats in each measure throughout the piece, creating an unstable effect.



Fauré and his mustache



Right-hand line from Prelude No. 4 (mm. 1-2). Hemiola is used in the first measure, before switching back to two beats in the second.

Francis Poulenc was a later French composer, known both for his lightweight, humorous pieces along with many sacred works. He was open about his homosexuality, and during the Nazi occupation of France in WWII, his status as a successful composer helped to shield him from persecution⁹. Throughout his life, he collaborated with and loved a number of gay musicians, artists, and writers. *Trois Novelettes* consists of three short pieces, two composed in 1927-28, and the third written later in 1959. The second *Novelette*, in B-flat minor, is dedicated to Poulenc’s friend and music critic Louis Laloy. This movement is stylistically similar to a *scherzo*, meaning “joke” or “jest” in Italian.

Sergei Prokofiev published the Cello Sonata in C Major one year after he was accused of “formalism” (form-based, rather than politically-motivated music) under the Zhdanov Decree of 1948. The cultural campaign sought to root out apolitical, non-socio-realist, and “cosmopolitan” influences on musical production of the Soviet Union, targeting six composers (the list also included Dmitri Shostakovich).¹⁰

This sonata was written for Russian cellist Mstislav Rostropovich, who was just 21 at the time. The movement swings playfully from the lowest to highest registers of the cello, and from the solemn *grave* tempo marking to dreamy *andante*, and then a lively *moderato animato* by the end. The piece was finally played in public in 1949, absent of the ailing Prokofiev himself, after a months-long approval process under the Zhdanov Doctrine. Prokofiev’s death was overshadowed by Stalin’s death on the same day in March 1953; among the members at the composer’s sparsely-attended funeral was Shostakovich.¹¹

⁷ Johann Mattheson, *Das Neu-Eröffnete Orchestre* (Hamburg: Benjamin Schillers Witwe, 1713), quoted in Hans Lenneberg, “Johann Mattheson on Affect and Rhetoric in Music,” *Journal of Music Theory* 2, no. 2 (November 1958), 193-236: 234-36.

⁸ “Gabriel Fauré,” *Deutsche Grammophon*, <https://www.deutschegrammophon.com/en/composers/gabriel-faure/biography>.

⁹ Julia Marcus, “Music for Lovers,” *Classical Radio Boston*, <https://www.classicalwcrb.org/blog/2025-06-30/music-for-lovers>.

¹⁰ R.M. Longyear, “Zhdanov Denounces ‘Formalism’ in Music,” *EBSCO*, 2023.

¹¹ Georg Predota, “The Illness, Sufferings and Final Days of Sergei Prokofiev,” *Interlude*, 5 March 2023.

Astor Piazzolla remains the most influential Argentinian tango composer to this day. Tango originated as a working-class dance and music movement with influences from the Cuban habanera, the Argentinian milonga, and the Afro-Uruguayan candombe. Piazzolla's inclusion of jazz and classical elements along with new instruments such as the saxophone and electric guitar revolutionized the genre into the *Nuevo tango* style mostly commonly associated with tango music today.

The *Primavera Porteña* is part of Piazzolla's *Cuatro Estaciones Porteñas*, his version of Vivaldi's *Four Seasons*. *Porteño/a*, literally "of the port," refers to someone from Buenos Aires. While the four pieces are usually performed independently of each other, when they are performed in sequence, Piazzolla orders them *Otoño-Invierno-Verano-Primavera*, an inversion of Vivaldi's order (Spring-Summer-Fall-Winter) and a play on the flipped seasons from Northern to Southern Hemisphere. The arrangement we are playing today was originally composed for Piazzolla's Quinteto Nuevo Tango which included violin, piano, electric guitar, double bass and bandoneón (a type of concertina quintessential to tango).



Piazzolla on bandoneón, top center, with his Quinteto Nuevo Tango in 1962



thank yous

This recital would not have been possible without the help of many people. Thank you to the ever-committed Jaz Dand for receiving our countless emails, questions, requests, and logistical tangles and answering them with time, patience, and help. Thank you to Anna Goudreau for all the unending technical and administrative support that makes Sage run and allows us to take lessons, practice, rehearse, and perform. Jaz and Anna are the backbone of Sage and they are the reason why we get to make music with ease.

Thank you to the coolest collaborative pianist, Lemmy Gurtowsky, for the thoughtfulness you pour into every piece of music that a student hands you. It has been an honor to play with you for this recital and many others.

Thank you to our incredible chamber coach, Jiayan Sun, as well as our teachers Volcy Pelletier, Yang Liu, and Robyn Quinnett, for guiding our trio musically for the past year. Thank you all for your generosity in sharing your knowledge, time, and mentorship with us.

And finally, thank you to our audience for slowing down on a hectic day in mid-April to listen. You make our music worthwhile!

thank yous cont.

From Ilana. The list of people who have influenced my musical career is far too long for this little blurb. Thank you to Laura Moylan, my piano teacher of more than ten years in Colorado. To Yang Liu, for the endless support and pushing me to grow in ways I didn't know were possible during my four years at Smith. I'm so appreciative of all the opportunities the music department has offered to me—especially as a non-music major. Thank you as well to the friends who hung out in practice rooms with me while I agonized over the same four measures for hours. And of course, to my family for continuously supporting me: my parents for their extensive classical music CD collection and always pushing me to practice, my brother for imbuing in me a (healthy) sense of competition, and my aunt, uncle, cousins, and grandpa in Connecticut for again and again making the drive up here for my shows and exhibitions.

From Tomoko. Thank you to my mother for taking me to every lesson I've ever had—for the gift of violin. I am grateful to my very first instructor Sasaki-sensei for teaching me discipline, to Jonathan Miron for fostering my musicianship and musical breadth, and to Anthony Berner and Robyn Quinnett for strengthening my artistry and voice. Thank you to my longtime conductors Nathan Hetherington and Ben Grow for helping me build my musical intuition, agency, and leadership over the course of many years in our orchestral classroom and to Jonathan Hirsh for his relentless encouragement and exemplary dedication to our orchestral experience. Finally, thank you to each and every one of my music buddies for their beautiful friendship. To share the gift of music with you all is a privilege.

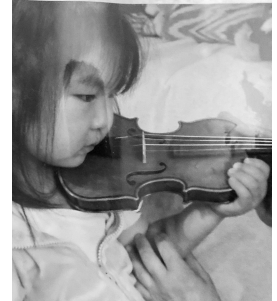
From Maia. My gratitude for the community of people who have helped me be here today: Cellists Brett and Stephanie Wallace in Colorado met me with challenges and trust always, and made their feline-filled home studio a safe space for me all throughout high school. Volcy Pelletier at Smith has pushed me to seek joy and rigor in my music in ways that have made me a far better musician and a more patient human being (though maybe she would disagree with the last point). My time at Smith would also not be the same without Melissa Parrish, who I was lucky enough to meet in my first semester. Her mentorship, teaching, and friendship have guided me towards literary passions and, more importantly, confidence to inhabit the weird and vaunted halls of Smith College. Friends, family, teachers, and fellow organizers have given me a home in SF, Colorado, Chicago, and Western Mass; thank you if you are reading this. Ilana and Tomoko, thank you for filling the past two semesters with laughter and levity and beautiful music. Lastly, to Mama, Baba, Lao Lao, Lao Yeh, Nai Nai, Lucy, Rowie, and Milla: thank you always for support, belonging, and love.

the musicians



Ilana Diddams is graduating with a double major in Studio Art (Installation) and Spanish. After graduating, they plan to road trip across the US to their hometown in Louisville, Colorado where they will be working at Creative Framing Art Gallery. Ilana started learning piano at the age of five and hasn't stopped since, playing in elementary school talent shows, accompanying choirs, performing at the 2024 Orbifold Global Music Festival in Sicily, and most recently, presenting a lecture-recital on the life and music of composer Florence Price (1887-1953).

Tomoko Hida is graduating with a major in Statistical & Data Sciences and a minor in Computer Science. This summer, she will be in Vienna to participate in orchestral accompaniment for productions of *The Magic Flute*, *Carmen*, and *Suor Angelica* with mentorship from members of the Vienna Philharmonic and Vienna Symphoniker. She began studying violin at age three and played in music ensembles at Berkshire Summer Music and Horace Mann School between 2014 and 2022. She has served as Concertmaster of the Smith College Orchestra since Fall 2024 and performed solo violin at the 2025 Smith College Concerto Concert last spring.



Maia Cheng Penuel is graduating with a major in English Literary Studies, minor in Studio Art, and certificate in Asian/Pacific/American studies. After Smith, they are remaining in Northampton for a year to live and work as a PCA. They began playing cello at age ten and have played in orchestras, chamber groups, and jam sessions throughout high school and college. Fun fact: Maia and Ilana went to high school together and co-founded their school's climate justice group. Their first time playing music together was Florence Price's "Adoration" in fall 2024.

Caro Faust will graduate with a double major in applied mathematics and physics. He began studying the violin at age six, focusing on solo performance before continuing his musical journey at Smith, where he also joined the orchestra. He currently serves as co-president of the Smith College Orchestra and principal second violin. He will also be performing solo violin in the Commencement Concert this coming May. Outside of his music and his classwork, he heads the Smith College Basketball Club and tends to his many house plants. After graduation, he hopes to take one huge deep breath, and then obtain a graduate degree in applied mathematics and eventually work as a mathematical biologist.

Lemuel Gurtowsky is an active collaborative pianist throughout the Pioneer Valley. Prior to joining Smith College, Lemuel was a staff accompanist and voice coach at the University of Massachusetts Amherst. Additionally, he accompanied the Springfield Symphony Chorus and has worked with music students and choral groups across the Five Colleges. He has also served as music director for the Unitarian Society of Northampton and Florence, and for Act Too Studio's opera workshop, a summer program for high school students. As a rock musician and songwriter, Gurtowsky has toured extensively, performing at The Music Hall of Williamsburg (NYC), Reading and Leeds festivals (UK), and SXSW (Austin, TX). His songs have appeared on NBC's "Parenthood" and MTV's "Fantasy Factory." Gurtowsky received his master's degree in collaborative piano from the University of Massachusetts Amherst, studying under Nadine Shank. He holds a bachelor's degree in music theory from The Hartt School, where he studied jazz piano with Andy Laverne.